

GROUP EXERCISE PLAYBOOK

The exercise isn't the task — assessors sit outside the circle marking behaviours. Nobody fails for a wrong answer; people fail for how they got there.

What's Being Scored — Your Six Points, Refined

BEHAVIOUR	SCORES	REFINEMENT
Challenge respectfully	CRM / assertiveness	Challenge the idea , never the person; concede gracefully when outvoted
Talk throughout	Engagement	Steady presence, not constant talking — contribute every few minutes, never vanish for five
Keep track of time	Situational awareness	Claim it out loud in minute one, then actually deliver the updates
Only speak if it adds	Communication quality	Never repeat a made point — add content, build, structure, or bring someone in
Bring people in	Leadership / teamwork	The highest-scoring behaviour available — do it at least twice
Use names	Rapport / attention	Write a seating map at intros; address people, not the table

Resolving the tension between “talk throughout” and “only if it adds”: when you have no new content, make a **process move** — summarise, time-check, test consensus, bring someone in. Process moves always add value.

The Opening Two Minutes — Scripted

1. **Introductions:** names said clearly, and **write a seating map** — you will not hold eight names under pressure; the map means you never fumble one.
2. **Claim timekeeper**, exact words: **I** “I’ll monitor the time and keep the group updated.”
3. **Offer structure as a question:** **I** “We’ve got 20 minutes — shall we take two to read individually, go round for first thoughts, then discuss and keep the last five to agree the answer?” Structure = leadership; the question mark = never dominance. The go-round also gets quiet people speaking early.

Phrase Bank — Say These, Not Improvised Versions

Challenging respectfully

“That’s a fair point, [name] — my concern with it is [reason]. How would we handle that?”

“I see it slightly differently. [Reasoning]. What am I missing?”

“Can I push back gently? If [X] happens, does the plan still work?”

Conceding: “That’s persuasive — I’m happy to go with [name]’s option.” (Once, meant, move on. Conceding aloud scores; sulking silence doesn’t.)

Timekeeping updates — at half, 10, 5 and 2 minutes

“Quick time check — halfway. We’ve settled [X]; still open is [Y].”

“Ten minutes left. Shall we start converging on a decision?”

“Five minutes — I suggest we lock the top three and spend the rest checking everyone’s happy.”

“Two minutes — [name], could you summarise what we’re submitting so we’re all agreed?”

Bringing people in — at least twice

“[Name], we haven’t heard from you yet — what’s your read on the problem?”

“[Name], you mentioned [earlier point] — does that change how you’d rank this?”

Caging a dominator — redirect, never confront

“That’s one strong option — before we settle, can we hear what [quiet name] thinks?”

“Hold that thought, [name] — I want to make sure we get everyone’s view in the time we’ve got.”

Process moves — your no-new-content default

Summarise: “So far we’ve agreed [X] and [Y]; the open question is [Z].”

Consensus: “Are we all comfortable with that, or does anyone have a concern we should hear?”

Park: “Good point — can we park it and come back if there’s time?”

Building on others — worth more than solo brilliance

“Building on [name]’s idea — combine it with [Y] and we cover both problems.”

Likely Formats and the Play for Each

- **Ranking / survival** (desert, sea, moon): individual read → go-round → discuss only the big disagreements → converge. Move: “We agree top three and bottom three — let’s spend our time on the middle.”
- **Planning with constraints** (budget/schedule/resources): you’re already timekeeper, so **delegate** the other role: “[Name], could you track the numbers as we go?” — delegating is leadership gold.
- **Discussion / consensus topic**: push the go-round early, summarise emerging camps by name, then propose a middle path or criteria to choose by.

Every format’s endgame: the group must actually finish. Running out of time reflects on everyone — your 5- and 2-minute calls prevent it.

Failure Modes — One of These Fails the Exercise

1. **Dominating** — talking over people, repeating louder, fighting after the group moved on
2. **Disappearing** — five silent minutes reads as disengaged; re-enter with a process move
3. **Arguing to win** — being right is worth nothing; the marks are in how you disagreed
4. **Point-scoring** — never correct someone in a way that diminishes them
5. **Dropping the time** — fatal if you claimed timekeeper and stopped delivering
6. **Groupthink shepherding** — racing to agreement unheard; near the end ask “does anyone see a problem with this?”

Rehearsal Before Friday

- **Phrase bank aloud daily** — timekeeper claim, one challenge, one bring-in, until reflex not recall
- **One scenario per evening, 15-min timer**, arguing both sides aloud with updates at 10/5/2 min:
 - *Desert survival*: vehicle down 100km from help — rank: water, mirror, map, coat, pistol, salt tablets, torch, compass, plastic sheet, edible-plants book
 - *Sea survival*: yacht sinking — rank: sextant, shaving mirror, water canister, mosquito net, rations, maps, seat cushion, oil can, radio, rope
 - *Planning*: charity open day — £500, one weekend, six volunteers: pick the event, split the budget
- **One live mock** with a friend playing a dominator — practise the redirect once and it’s available Friday
- **On the day**: seating map + names → timekeeper claim → structure offer. Then the playbook runs itself.

The mindset sentence: “My job isn’t to have the best answer — it’s to make this group better at reaching one.” Every behaviour above follows from it — and it’s a precise description of the First Officer they’re selecting for.